Style & Presence

PROFESSIONAL DRESS AND PERSONAL PRESENCE FOR LEADERS



ISSUE 2 · NOVEMBER 2026

Business Casual Without the Guesswork

— Build a dependable foundation
— Fit still rules
— Read the setting

By Dr. Solomon Chukwuemeka Awusah (Non-Clinical Strategist) · solomonawusah.com

Business Casual Without the Guesswork

Business casual is the most common dress code and the most confusing. A few simple principles make it easy to look polished and appropriate.

By Dr. Solomon Chukwuemeka Awusah (Non-Clinical Strategist) · November 7, 2026

Build a dependable foundation

The easiest way to handle business casual is to rely on a small set of versatile pieces that work together. For many professionals, that means a few pairs of well-fitting trousers or chinos in neutral colors, several collared shirts or fine-knit tops, one or two unstructured blazers and a reliable pair of leather shoes.

Neutral colors such as navy, gray, tan, white and light blue combine easily. With a modest wardrobe built around them, getting dressed becomes a matter of choosing rather than inventing an outfit each morning.

Quality matters more than quantity. A few well-made pieces in durable fabrics such as cotton twill, wool and fine merino will outlast and outperform a closet full of items that lose their shape after a few washes.

Fit still rules

Casual does not mean loose or sloppy. Trousers should sit comfortably at the waist and break lightly over the shoe. Shirts should allow movement without billowing, and sleeves should end near the wrist. A blazer should close without pulling and sit cleanly across the shoulders.

A good tailor can make modest adjustments that dramatically improve how clothes look. Hemming trousers and taking in a shirt are small investments that make inexpensive pieces look considered.

Read the setting

Business casual varies widely from one workplace to another, and even from one day to the next. A client meeting calls for a sharper version than a quiet day in the office. A conference may lean more relaxed, while a board presentation may call for a jacket and possibly a tie.

When unsure, it is usually wiser to dress slightly more formally than expected. A blazer can always be removed. Observing what respected colleagues and hosts wear is one of the most reliable guides.

Travel days and video calls bring their own considerations. A wrinkle-resistant blazer and a solid-colored shirt work well on camera, while comfortable yet presentable layers help on long journeys that end in meetings.

Shoes and accessories carry weight

Shoes often reveal more about attention to detail than any other item. Clean, well-maintained leather loafers, derbies or simple boots suit most business casual settings. Athletic sneakers rarely do, unless the workplace culture clearly accepts them.

Accessories should be simple and coordinated. A leather belt that matches the shoes, a quiet watch and a well-kept bag complete the look without drawing attention away from the person wearing them.

Socks deserve a moment of thought too. They should be long enough that no skin shows when seated, and in colors that complement the trousers or shoes. Rotating shoes between days and using shoe trees helps them keep their shape and last for years.

Grooming finishes the look

Even the best clothing falls short without basic grooming. Neat hair, trimmed nails and clothes that are clean and pressed signal care and preparation. Wrinkled shirts and scuffed shoes undo much of the effort put into choosing an outfit.

A few minutes the evening before, setting out clothes, checking for stains or loose buttons and giving shoes a quick polish, make mornings calmer and the result more consistent.

Mind the etiquette that goes with it

A relaxed dress code does not relax professional manners. Punctuality, a firm and friendly greeting, attentive listening and putting the phone away during conversations all contribute to presence. Clothing opens the door, but conduct is what people remember.

Posture and attention count as well. Standing and sitting with ease, making appropriate eye contact and giving people full attention when they speak create

an impression of confidence that no garment can supply on its own. Remembering names, following up on commitments and thanking hosts afterward complete the picture.

Polished, not stiff

Business casual works best when it looks effortless, and that ease comes from preparation. A dependable set of versatile pieces, careful attention to fit, awareness of the setting, quality shoes and simple accessories, and consistent grooming together create a look that is professional without being formal.

The aim is not to impress with clothing but to let it support the work, so that attention stays where it belongs: on the person and the conversation.

Read online at https://solomonawusah.com/style-and-presence/issues/issue-02.html